On Childhood – A Collection

By Billy Collins, Fanny Howe and Bassey Ikpi

On Turning Ten by Billy Collins

(Pg 48) The whole idea of it makes me feel
like I'm coming down with something,
something worse than any stomachache
or the headaches I get from reading in bad light -
a kind of measles of the spirit,
a mumps of the psyche,
a disfiguring chicken pox of the soul.

You tell me it is too early to be looking back,
but that is because you have forgotten
the perfect simplicity of being one
and the beautiful complexity introduced by two.
But I can lie on my bed and remember every digit.
At four I was an Arabian wizard.
I could make myself invisible

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by drinking a glass of milk a certain way.
At seven I was a soldier, at nine a prince.

INTRODUCTION

I'm struggling with the idea of growing up. I remember sitting at my desk, working on an AP English essay and being overwhelmed with a sense of grief and terror that my childhood was ending. I am growing up . . . how terrifying! I looked around at my classmates and could see them all – colorful plastic barrettes, ponies on our t-shirts and gaps in our smiles that were rewarded by a visit from the tooth fairy. We loved to play tag; we loved to giggle and imagine. Now it's almost time to take our first solo plunges into adulthood. And I imagine a life without tag, without giggles; A life where reality slowly stamps out imagination. Am I ready?

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At four I was an Arabian wizard.
I could make myself invisible
by drinking a glass of milk a certain way.
At seven I was a soldier, at nine a prince.

But now I am mostly at the window
watching the late afternoon light.
Back then it never fell so solemnly

against the side of my tree house,
and my bicycle never leaned against the garage
as it does today,
all the dark blue speed drained out of it.

This is the beginning of sadness, I say to myself,
as I walk through the universe in my sneakers.
It is time to say good-bye to my imaginary friends,
time to turn the first big number.

It seems only yesterday I used to believe
there was nothing under my skin but light.
If you cut me I would shine.
But now if I fall upon the sidewalks of life,
I skin my knees. I bleed.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Billy Collins
Book: The Art of Drowning, Pg 48
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Second Childhood by Fanny Howe

I have a fairy rosary called Silver who answers questions when I dangle her in the sun at the window. So I have asked her if I have a big ego and she swings from side to side to say no.

We have other children for friends.

We don't understand why we are here in the world with horrible grown-ups or what the lessons are that we're supposed to learn.

It's not helpful for us to hear ourselves described in religious, geriatric or psychological terms, because we don't remember what they mean.

One cruel female said, "Don't laugh so much. You're not a child."

My cheeks burned and my eyes grew hot.

I decided to stop becoming an adult. That day I chose to blur facts, fail at tests, and slouch under a hood. School was

my first testing ground. I misunderstood lessons, assignments, meanings of poems and stories, and misinterpreted the gestures of characters in novels. I was awestruck by geology but mixed up the ages of rocks. I stared and giggled and refused to take orders and was punished.

Throughout my life I have remained vague and have accepted the humiliation it brought, almost as if stupefaction were a gift. I willfully repeat my mistakes over and over and never learn from experience.

Every day has been a threat to this attitude, so I avoid obligations. For example, last night I dreamed I was on an airplane that was open to the sky and a storm was coming from a hive of stars, and I wanted to sit beside my daughter to watch the wind as we strapped ourselves tight to the invisible seats and stayed awake. If we had been grown-ups, we wouldn't have been able to see the stars or the storm. We would have perished.

So my commitment to childhood has once again been affirmed.

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You might think I am just old, but I have finally decided to make the decision to never grow up and remain under my hood.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Fanny Howe
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Publisher: Poetry Foundation
Date (Month/Year): September 2013

Can purchase hard copy on-line at
https://pty.pcdfusion.com/pcd/ShoppingCart/store/30/Product/ZPTY%201308
Poem can be found on-line at
https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poetrymagazine/articles/70043/second-childhood

Sometimes Silence is the Loudest Kind of Noise by Bassey Ikpi

Sometimes silence is the loudest kind of noise
Like sometimes it was best when
Girls were girls and boys were boys.
Like back when freeze tag was a mating dance.
Like back when "Do Over" meant you got another chance.
Like back when anxiety was worrying if Wonder Woman

would make it out alive.
Like back when freedom was sliding backwards on a slide.
Like back when success was jumping off a swing and
Landing on your feet, then
Doing it all over again.
Like new shoes made you run faster.
Like getting Ms. Gross again for math was a disaster.
Like failure was a word we hadn't even learned to spell yet.
Like promises were sealed and kept with pinky bets.
Like a challenge was a double dare.
Like ugly was a cock-eyed stare.

And you liked it…
Like when you flipped your eyelids inside out
To impress that boy across the room,
'Cause that's all it took.
And there was no such thing as too soon,
As long as you checked the right box in that note from
across the room,
The one that he…passed her.
Back when, "I don't know, maybe" was a legitimate answer.
Back when, "I need space" meant he needed more elbow

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room to draw,
So he got on the floor and he colored outside the lines.
Like the lines of color were on the floor,
So we just existed in sandboxes and playgrounds.
And we hop-scotched and dodgeballed
And everything I needed to know, I learned in a shopping
mall.
Like don't wander off on your own,
Like know who you are,
Like know where you came from,
Like never let go of your mother's hand no matter what you
do,
Like if you get lost, just stand there until someone finds
you,
And someone will always look for you
Because someone will always miss you
And someone will always find you
And when you cry, someone will always remind you
In that quiet, quiet lullaby voice,
That sometimes silence is the loudest kind of noise.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Bassey Ikpi
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Printed poem can be found on-line at https://badilishapoetry.com/bassey-ikpi/

AWARD HISTORY

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